

Grammar 16 A: The passive voice

1. The importance of the passive voice

In the Malagasy language, *the person and the object are just as important* as the action, or whoever does the action. The passive voice is a way of building a sentence to show this. In Malagasy, the passive voice is common, even as natural as the active voice. What we pay attention to and what we understand depend on the voice used in the sentence, even if the end result is the same.

The passive voice is used to put the emphasis on the object (a person or a thing) rather than on the action, or on the subject / actor as in the active voice. So if you want to emphasise the person or the thing, you need to use the passive voice, which answers the questions ***IZA no . . . ?*** (off) / ***ZOVY . . . ?*** (tsm) (Who is . . . ?) or ***INONA no . . . ?*** (off) / ***INO . . . ?*** (tsm) (What is . . . ?)

Let us take the example 'wash the clothes':

WASH *manasa* (active) – *sasana* (passive)
THE CLOTHES *ny lamba*

In an active-voice sentence, '***manasa lamba***', the emphasis is on washing (a Malagasy speaker hears what is being done), while in a passive-voice sentence, '***sasana ny lamba***', the emphasis is on the clothes (a Malagasy speaker hears what is being washed). Yet in the end, the clothes are washed in both cases.

– *Active voice – emphasis on the action*

Manasa ovy izy (He washes potatoes)

- Manasa ovy izy (fa tsy mitetika ovy).
  He washes potatoes (he does not chop potatoes).

– *Passive voice – emphasis on the object*

Sasany **ny** ovy (He washes **the** potatoes)

- Sasany ny ovy (fa tsy ny karaoty).
  He washes **the** potatoes (not the carrots).

Active voice – emphasis on the action or the subject

Ex:

- Manasa ovy **izy** (*fa tsy mitetika karaoty*).
  He washes potatoes (he does not chop carrots).
- **Izy** *no manasa ovy (fa tsy I Soa.)*
  It is he who washes the potatoes (not Soa).

Match the corresponding active sentences in Malagasy (a – i) and in English (1 – 8) in this table, using the lexicon below.

Malagasy	English
a. ***Manasa*** vilia izy fa tsy manadio trano. b. ***Mahandro*** vary zaho fa tsy mitetika hena. d. ***Mividy*** tongolo be I Soa fa tsy mamboly tongolo be. e. ***I Koto*** no manadio birao fa tsy I Soa. f. ***I Soa*** no nividy vary fa tsy zaho. g. ***Hanasa*** lamba I Soa fa tsy hahandro vary. h. ***Zaho*** no mitetika manga fa tsy izy. i. ***Manasa*** tànana izy fa tsy manasa lamba.	1. ***It is Soa*** who bought rice, not me. 2. I ***cook*** rice; I do not chop meat. 3. She ***does*** the washing-up, not the housework. 4. ***It is me*** who chops mangoes, not him. 5. ***It is Koto*** who cleans the office, not Soa. 6. He ***washes*** his hands, not clothes. 7. Soa ***will do*** the laundry but will not cook rice. 8. Soa ***buys*** onions; she does not grow them.

Passive voice – emphasis on the object

Ex:

- Sasany **ny ovy** (fa tsy ny karaoty).
  She washes the potatoes (not the carrots).
- **Ny ovy** no sasany (fa tsy ny karaoty.)
  It is the potatoes that she washes (not the carrots).

Match the corresponding passive sentences in Malagasy (j – r) and in English (9 – 16) in this table, using the lexicon below.

Malagasy	English
j. Sasan'I Soa ***ny fiara*** fa tsy ny trano. k. ***Ny trano*** no diovin'I Koto fa tsy ny zaridaina. l. Andrahoiny ***ny vary*** fa tsy ny hena. m. ***Ny manga*** no tetehan'I Soa fa tsy ny tongolo be. n. ***Ny vary*** no vidiany fa tsy ny manga. o. Tsy ***tongolo be*** no ambolen'I Soa fa vary. p. Tsy ***manga*** no sasany fa tànana. r. ***Hena*** no vidiko fa tsy manga sy vary.	9. It is ***the mangoes*** that Soa chops, not the onions. 10. It is not ***onions*** that Soa plants, but rice. 11. I buy ***the meat***, but not the mangoes and the rice. 12. It is ***the house*** that Koto cleans, not the garden. 13. It is ***the rice*** that she buys, not the mangoes. 14. It is not ***mangoes*** that she washes, but her hands. 15. She cooks ***the rice***, not the meat. 16. Soa washes ***the car***, not the house.

Lexicon

Active verb / passive verb	Object	Subject
Manasa / sasana (to wash) Manadio / diovina (to clean) Mahandro / andrahoina (to cook) Mitetika / tetehana (to chop) Mividy / vidina (to buy) Mamboly / ambolena / avoly (to plant)	Vilia / kapila (plates, dishes) Trano (house) Vary (rice) Manga (mango) Tànana (hands) Hena (meat) Zaridaina (garden) Tongolo be (onion) Lamba (clothes) Birao (office) Fiara (car)	I Soa (Soa) I Koto (Koto) Izy (he/she) Zaho / aho (I)

Answers

a > 3 b > 2 d > 8 e > 5 f > 1 g > 7 h > 4 i > 6
j > 16 k > 12 l > 15 m > 9 n > 13 o > 10 p > 14 r > 11